

## BLUE SHEEP FILMS

### Reader's Report

**TITLE:** NOMAD

**WRITER:** Sacha Mitchell

**READER:** Internal development pass      **DATE:** July 28, 2026

**FORMAT:** Short screenplay. Draft v1.8, 22 scenes, approx. 17–19 min. Accompanying 2-page pitch document and summary.

**Genre:** Drama / near-future thriller

**Period:** Near future — deliberately close to contemporary

**Location:** An emptying North American office floor; a suburban apartment block; a relocation storefront in an office park; Mexico City

**CONCEPT:** In a near future where synthetic video is indistinguishable from real footage except for a sub-second latency the eye learns to feel, a burnt-out identity-verification worker follows his best friend into a paradise abroad — and finds the paradise is a render, the friend is a machine, and the operation harvesting them both is already recruiting the next one through him.

**SYNOPSIS:** A poolside frame at golden hour. A laugh lands a half-beat late. A single frame stutters.

On an office floor at its midpoint, CAIRNS (30s, loud, likeable) packs his desk into a printer-paper box and performs an exit for a floor that isn't watching. Only WILL and JOHN are. A ROBOT BOSS — a monitor on a stand carrying the boss's always-available face — rolls up to accept a review; at his house, the real boss ignores the feed while his own face goes on answering for him. In the elevator bank Cairns sells a SERVICE that handles everything for one fee and can answer no follow-up questions. He and Will run their handshake, the dumb elaborate one, and the doors close on him mid-sell. On the emptied desk, a branded welcome folder, squared to the edge to be found. John drops into the abandoned chair and spins it.

ONE YEAR LATER. The same floor, mostly empty. Motion-sensor lights click on ahead of Will in sequence. At 8:55 the coffee machine brews a full pot and he pours its only cup. At his desk he audits the machine's fraud calls — one button, APPROVE, a streak counter climbing — until he stops on a face verified at 98%, replays three seconds, and overrides it as synthetic on the evidence of the man's eyes. His monitor reads SYSTEM 99.1 / WILL 96.8 — TOP HUMAN PERFORMER. When he logs back in, the system stalls on his own face. Later, when he intervenes on a fraud he is certain of, a coaching module auto-plays and the system clears the case without him.

Cairns calls from the pool. Two women beside him observe, in subtitled Spanish, that a year in he still points at the menu. Cairns invokes MICHELLE — one word to her and Will is set up by Friday — and is pulled from frame. On the dead sales floor John, who has never left the country, runs a mini-putt course through hole 7 and asks nothing except that his friends stay. Neither man can say who Michelle is; the Service was a company. They shrug it off.

At home: a family call that ends first from the other side, the family house listed for sale, a building of lockboxes and rolling suitcases where Will is the last person who actually lives on his floor. He opens the Service page.

The storefront sits between a vape shop and a notary, a paradise reel looping over a dying pothos. On the reel a family laughs a half-beat late; Will clocks it instantly, professionally, and files it where it costs him nothing. He is scanned, captured, and asked to describe his dream place. He answers without guarding it — high floor, light in the morning, somewhere he doesn't have to explain himself — and the camera

keeps rolling after he's done. Michelle's email arrives before he's out of the parking lot. That night a welcome ad plays starring Will himself, composited into Cairns' paradise. For half a second his own eyes look wrong. His hand is on the scrub bar before he knows why; he is one keystroke from the form he fills out for a living. He closes the window instead.

The floor is closed for good. John's answer is a mini-putt championship on the last day, and a putter with WILL taped to the grip.

In Mexico City, Will takes an apartment somebody is still moving out of — boxes by the door, nail holes, eleven years of a child's height marks pencilled down the frame, mail still in the slot. He looks at the height marks and takes it. He lives entirely in English and is always accommodated. Two locals discuss a building that emptied inside a month; he walks through the shot without hearing it. At the end of a block, a gaunt man works the curb, holding a phone up to passing faces like ID: IDENTITY NOT VERIFIED — REFERENCE ON FILE. It is Cairns. He can speak; he has been saying his own name all morning. Will sees him for one full second, then puts it down, phone up, and is gone.

A call. The poolside frame. Will raises a fist and starts the handshake, and the likeness follows — a half-beat late, one move wrong, the move the real Cairns never misses. Four seconds of Will fully awake, and the call goes on pleasantly around him. Alone, he drags two windows frame by frame, finds five o'clock light behind a man who says he just woke, and isolates the laugh on a waveform: 0.4 late, in the same place, every time. Call metadata puts every message from Cairns for months at one building twenty minutes away.

He goes in behind a delivery cart. Upstairs there is no pool: chairs, capture rigs, humming racks. Through a propped fire door, the render farm — an operator types and a poolside evening assembles in seconds; a slider drags a nonexistent girl's laugh warmer; a wall of scanned location plates including a rooftop he stood on last week; an outbound queue of hundreds of warm emails, every one signed MICHELLE; his own welcome ad refining, with a familiar readout beside it, WILL 96.8, and the model's number higher. From the next row, his own laugh. The real one. On the worst screen, Cairns' likeness on a call with Will's likeness, version numbers in the corner. An operator clocks him in a doorway reflection and doesn't hurry — just taps something in. Every way down runs through the same desk.

Intercut: the last day on the dead floor, a sagging banner, most names never filled in, two people leaving in coats, then just John in a homemade referee shirt, two beers, and Will's putter leaning against hole 7, reserved. And a verification room, where Will — nine years of being right about this machine — puts his face to a liveness rig. It reads the polished model as authentic and flags the live man as SYNTHETIC. STATUS: SYNTHETIC · RETAINED FOR REFERENCE. Behind him, numbered lockers; some cleared and not refilled, the ones the model no longer needs to check itself against. One readable tag: CAIRNS · v6. An attendant peels a numbered tag from a sheet of them and clips it to his collar.

John's laptop chimes. He answers, and we see it before he does: the poolside frame, and "WILL" in it, tanned and easy and warm, who knows about the bracket and hole 7 and the putter, who can't make it, but listen — come down here, he'll set him up, there's a woman called Michelle, by Friday. Behind him the water moves not wrong exactly, just not the way water moves. Something crosses John's face. For one second he almost catches it. I love you, man. A half-beat late. The call ends. John sits alone in the half-dismantled floor and starts to type back.

**ANALYSIS:** This is a genuinely strong concept executed with unusual discipline, and it is not yet the film it is capable of being. The premise is the good kind — the mechanism is the irony, so the story generates itself rather than being bolted to a device. A man whose profession is certifying that people are real is un-certified by his own machine, and the film never has to argue the point because the plot performs it. The world is coherent, the rules hold, and the reveal structure is sound. The writing at its best is exact and unsentimental: a coffee machine brewing a full pot at 8:55 for one cup, motion-sensor lights

as a runway for nobody, lockers whose empty slots are the people the model no longer needs to check itself against. That last image is the strangest and best thing in the script and belongs to no one else.

The central weakness is emotional rather than structural, and it is the one thing standing between this draft and a very good film. The climax depends entirely on a handshake — the unforgeable thing that existed only between two people and was therefore never in the dataset. That is a genuinely excellent idea and the film's real thesis. But the handshake appears once, as a single line of stage direction, described as fast, perfect, muscle memory — which is unlearnable for an audience. The real Will and the real Cairns share under a minute of screen time and not one line of dialogue with each other. The film asks us to grieve a friendship it never shows us, and at the moment of the failed handshake the honest audience experience is that something happened and the actor's face says it was bad. Relatedly, "I love you, man" is spoken twice in this script and never once by a living person — flawless as irony, impossible as grief, and it means the copy is warmer and more available than the man for most of the running time.

The second reservation is tonal. The script sustains a single register — dry, clipped, ironic — from the first frame to the last, and the effect is that the film's antagonist (a corporate voice that means nothing warmly) and the film's narration (a voice that means everything coldly) sit at the same temperature. There is no warm room anywhere in the picture, no before against which the loss can be measured. The prologue in particular teaches the audience in ten seconds that paradise is fake, which protects the film from sentimentality and simultaneously removes any possibility of the audience wanting what Will wants. Since the engine of the story is that he wants it enough to sell his face, that is a real cost. The correction is not more style; it is one sequence of unguarded warmth early — the night the three of them built the mini-putt course and invented the handshake would do all of this work at once, and would convert every act-three prop into a relic.

Third, and the most straightforward to address: the script is written in places as précis rather than as scenes. "Cairns brags about a SERVICE — handles everything, one fee — and can't answer a single follow-up" is the inciting mechanism of the entire film, summarised. The Mexico City establishing passage is four sentences of character notes standing where behaviour should be. The render farm — the film's revelation set piece — is a sequence of six screens described in independent paragraphs; reorder three of them and nothing changes, which means it is a montage rather than a scene, and the protagonist wants nothing while he is in it. Each of these is a place where a director will need staging the page has not yet supplied.

Two structural questions worth raising before a production draft. First, scope: 22 scenes across 18 minutes is a feature's coverage rate at a short's duration, and the script's best writing consistently appears where it stops covering ground and starts staging — the apartment viewing, the two-window comparison, the championship floor. Second, and more interesting: the premise holds that rendered and real are indistinguishable, and the film then travels to Mexico City and photographs it, which hands the audience ground truth the characters don't have. A version in which Will never leaves — where paradise exists only ever as a frame inside a screen — would be cheaper, smaller, and formally in agreement with its own thesis. That is a creative question rather than a note, but it is the one worth asking first.

From a production standpoint this is notably achievable. The bulk of the film is a dying office floor, an apartment, a storefront and one server room, with a small cast and no crowd work. The paradise material is by definition a render, which is both the theme and the budget line. The principal cost centre is the render-farm sequence, and it is written so that scale can be dialled. Casting risk is moderate and concentrated: Will must hold a nearly silent lead — four speeches, 24 words — and John must carry the final image on very few lines, which means both parts need actors who can play interior life without dialogue.

**TARGET AUDIENCE:** Adults 25–54. Festival short programming with strong streaming and anthology potential; the premise travels internationally and the concept is legible in a logline, which is an advantage in the short-film market.

**READER'S RECOMMENDATION:** Recommended, with reservations

A distinctive, intelligent and formally disciplined short with a premise that is genuinely its own and one image — the retained original, kept alive as a calibration reference — that no one else has staged. The reservations are specific and all addressable before a production draft: the friendship the climax rests on needs to be dramatised rather than asserted, the script needs one warm room to measure its losses against, and the passages currently written as summary need to become scenes. None of these are structural failures; the architecture is sound. They are the difference between a film that is admired and a film that lands.